sustained speed," says Pawar. "These horses can gallop for 80 km at a stretch."

As for its smaller size, Pawar reckons that the lack of proper breeding, inbreeding, lack of nutritious feed and use as draught animals since a young age has perhaps stunted the height of the horses over the past decades. Historically, too, records suggest, Indian horses were smaller. Indeed, while thoroughbreds stand 65-70 inches tall from the tip of their foreleg to the withers (the ridge between a horse's shoulder blades), Marwari horses measure 60-64 inches and Kathiawari horses about 59 inches. The Bhimthadis stand at a shorter 55-56 inches on an average, though records indicate they may once have been 58-59 inches tall.

Mehta speculates that the Bhimthadi may even have been one of the original breeds of horses extant in India before the advent of equines from outside and before such arrivals helped develop native breeds like Marwaris and Kathiawaris.

## The Fall and Rise

What led to the decline of the Bhimthadis in the first place and what explains their survival? In her 2021 book *The Tale of the Horse: A History of India on Horseback*, University of Edinburgh historian Yashaswini Chandra says that the Europeanisation of the taste in horses resulted in "the fall of Indian breeds", including the Deccanis/ Bhimthadis. The latter, she wrote, "became practically extinct in the sense that they are not officially recognised as a breed as their distinctive features are no longer definable."

Mehta points out that the constant march of ever more sophisticated firearms did away with the need for large bodies of cavalry, while mechanised transport dealt another blow. Crucially, the decline of the Maratha military power deprived the Bhimthadi of its largest users. Around 1827-28, Pawar notes, the British had started a stud farm at Alegaon-Paga in Pune district for the Bhimthadi horses, but nothing came of it. With its 'breeding tracts' limited to the basins of the Bhima and Nira rivers—in the districts of Pune, Satara, Sangli, Kolhapur, Solapur and Ahmednagar—the Bhimthadis seemed to be fated for obscurity.

If the breed survived, it was because of their utility to nomadic pastoralists from the Dhangar community, and farmers like Mandlik Kapre from Bolhegaon in Ahmednagar, who have been rearing them as part of a family tradition. These days, Bhimthadis also ferry tourists and serve as pack horses at pilgrimage centres like Vaishno Devi and hill stations like Matheran.

Sandip Bodage, president of the Akhil Bharatiya Bailgada Sharyat Sanghatana (All India Bullock cart Race Federation), says that the thriving local bull-racing tradition also played a part in the Bhimthadis' survival. The horses are used to provide a direction to the bulls during the races and are ridden bareback, requiring great horsemanship. They are also used in 'tonga races' in Ahmednagar district. "The Bhimthadis have a spring action when they start racing and have a faster pickup rate than other breeds," says Pawar. "This is why they are used for navigation in these races."

"It was their utility in bullock-cart races that led to farmers preserving the horses," agrees Bodage, who is based at Nighoj in Ahmednagar district, and owns four Bhimthadi mares for bullock-cart racing. "However, they were oblivious to the Bhimthadis' proud lineage. They were referred to as tattus (ponies) or gavran (native/ rustic) horses."

The recognition of the Bhimthadis as a separate breed and a Pawar-organised horse show in January at Baramati has led to renewed interest in the Bhimthadi among farmers and breeders. "Now they have realised these horses have a martial tradition dating to the era of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj," says Pawar. Bodage, too, can't resist singing paeans to the Bhimthadis' resilience. "I cannot recollect the last instance when they had to be given any medicines," he says. They can be trained quickly, are sensitive and easy to maintain." They also require less fodder—around 10 kg daily per animal, compared to 30-40 kg for Marwari horses.

Endorsements such as these and now official recognition may yet help the Bhimthadi recapture its past glory. ■



**"Their utility in bullock cart races led farmers to preserve the horses. They did not even know these were the famed Bhimthadis"**

**–SANDIP BODAGE**

*President, Akhil Bharatiya Bailgada Sharyat Sanghatana*

**"Recognition as a separate breed can rejuvenate Bhimthadis through government policy initiatives. They are a good, hardy breed"**



**–SHARAT MEHTA**

*Head, Regional Station, National Research Centre of Equines, Bikaner*